

Lantern Tides Playtest Report

Vertical slice review, build 0.6.5. Prepared by Angela Brooks. February 16, 2026.

Summary

This report covers the closed playtest rounds run on the web build and two desktop builds between January 4 and February 10, 2026, ahead of the Cascadia Indie Showcase demo on November 8, 2026. Twenty sessions were logged across builds 0.6.2 through 0.6.5. The goal was to confirm that chapters one through three hold up unattended and that the chapter four teaser reads as a teaser rather than a broken area. The headline result is good. The festival opener and the general store both complete without help, the river road bridge softlock is fixed, and the only remaining crash sits in the unfinished night sky scene where the audio branch is still landing.

Method

Sessions were unmoderated where possible. Testers were given a single line of guidance, sit down and play until you stop, and nothing else. The web build was the default surface because it needs no install and matches how most showcase visitors will first meet the game. Two desktop builds covered the cases the web export cannot, longer sessions and the night ambience loop at full quality. Each session recorded the furthest scene reached, minutes played, and the reason the tester stopped. Crash reports were captured automatically. No personal data was collected beyond a first name and which build was played.

Eight testers took part, drawn from the studio cohort, the Thursday tabletop group, and two players from the online devlog who asked to help. None had seen the river road chapter before this round, which kept the bridge puzzle honest.

Coverage by chapter

Counts below are the furthest scene each session reached. Of twenty sessions, all twenty reached the festival, seventeen reached the general store, thirteen reached the river road, and seven pushed into the night sky teaser.

Chapter	Scene tag	Sessions ended here	Minutes range	Outcome
1 The Lantern Festival	ch1_festival_intro	3	16 to 18	completes unattended
2 The General Store	ch2_general_store	4	22 to 34	completes, barter puzzle clear
3 The River Road	ch3_river_road	6	27 to 33	completes, bridge fixed in 0.6.3
4 The Night Sky	ch4_night_sky_wip	7	9 to 19	teaser only, ends at unfinished area

Sessions ran from nine minutes in the unfinished night sky area to thirty four in the general store, which matches the slow, attention first pace the design is built around. No tester rushed the dialogue, and three of them sat through the river road monologue twice.

Sessions by build

Build	Sessions	Completed a chapter	Softlocks	Crashes
0.6.2-vslice	5	2	1	0
0.6.3-vslice	6	3	0	1
0.6.4-vslice	5	2	0	0
0.6.5-vslice	4	2	0	1

The softlock count drops to zero after 0.6.2. Both crashes trace to the same unfinished night sky edge and not to two separate faults. Completion holds steady across builds because the first three chapters were stable early and most of the build to build change was art and audio, not logic.

Defects and resolutions

1. River road bridge softlock. In build 0.6.2 the lantern puzzle on the bridge could be left in a state where neither lantern would relight, blocking progress. Two sessions hit it. Fixed in 0.6.3 by resetting the lantern state when the player steps off the bridge tile. No recurrence after the fix.
2. Night sky crash. Builds 0.6.3 and 0.6.5 logged a crash when the player walks past the unfinished edge of the chapter four scene. The crash capture tool flagged a missing tile reference. This is expected for a work in progress area and is gated behind a soft wall in the demo build so showcase visitors cannot reach it.
3. General store barter readability. One tester missed that prices update after the first trade. Not a defect, but the number tween is too fast. Slowed the count animation for the demo.
4. Letter chapter font size. Two testers found the letter text small at the web resolution. Queued a one step size bump and a slightly heavier weight for the handwritten passages.

What testers remembered

Asked the day after to name one moment, testers named the graveyard scene on the river road and the first time a lantern pulls them into a held memory. Nobody named a mechanic. That is the right answer for a game about attention as a form of care. The quiet beats are doing the work the loud ones usually get credit for.

Two notes came up more than once. The font in the letter chapter is a touch small at the web resolution, and the night ambience cuts a half second short on the loop. The first is a quick change. The second is on the audio branch with Ravi and is already in his queue.

One tester described the pacing as a game that trusts you to slow down. That line is going on the showcase booth card.

Showcase readiness

The demo scope is chapters one through three polished plus the chapter four teaser, which the build supports today. Remaining work before November 8 is the letter chapter font pass, the audio loop fix, and one more unattended run on a fresh machine to confirm the soft wall holds. Vertical slice sits at roughly sixty percent of the full game, three of seven chapters fully drafted, which is on track for the showcase target and well ahead of the full thesis deadline in May 2027.

Changelog touched by this round

Build	Date	Change
0.6.3-vslic	2026-01-10	bridge lantern state reset, fixes softlock
0.6.4-vslic	2026-01-19	river road art pass, dialogue timing
0.6.5-vslic	2026-02-02	night sky soft wall, crash gated for demo
0.6.6 planned	after font pass	slow barter tween, letter font, loop fix

Next playtest round is scheduled after the letter chapter font pass lands. Build 0.6.6 will carry the slowed barter animation and the loop fix. Report ends.